

Community gardens have long been treated as a small matter of local pride, a patch of tomatoes beside a parking lot and little more. Yet the records of the three cities studied here show that these plots did far more work than their size suggests. They gave neighbors a reason to meet, and they gave councils a cheap way to put empty land to use.

The first city to adopt a formal program did so in 1974. Its planners expected a short experiment that would end when the vacant lots were sold. Instead the program outlasted three mayors and grew from nine plots to more than two hundred.

Participation was not evenly spread. Gardens in older neighborhoods filled quickly, while newer districts struggled to find volunteers. Organizers blamed distance from transit and the lack of a shared tool shed, not any lack of interest.

A volunteer coordinator described the turning point plainly: once a garden had a water line, membership roughly doubled within a single season. The council eventually funded water access for every plot on public land, which is the policy most often copied elsewhere.

Critics raised a fair objection. Land that serves as a garden today may be wanted for housing tomorrow, and a program that depends on temporary leases can leave gardeners with nothing. Two of the three cities answered by granting longer leases and recording the plots in the land register.

The third city chose a different path and kept short leases, arguing that flexibility mattered more than permanence. Its gardens closed at twice the rate of the others, a result the city attributed to rising land values rather than to the program.

Taken together, the three cases suggest a modest conclusion. Community gardens **succeed where** the city provides basic infrastructure and a stable claim to the land, and they fail where either is missing. Nothing here requires large budgets or new institutions.

Further work should follow these gardens over a longer period. Ten years of records is enough to show survival rates, but it is too short to say whether the neighborhood benefits endure after the original volunteers move on.